

Gedianov, and his mistress, Alexander Borodin was born in 1883 and baptized as the son of one of his father's serfs. Prince Gedianov stood by the boy and his mother, Avdotya Antonova: he lived with them in St. Petersburg during Alexander's childhood. In 1839, he arranged for Avdotya to marry a medic; and, just before his death, freed his son from serfdom (see [box](#)).

Alexander's home education included flute lessons but his musical interests expanded after Mikhail Shchiglev joined the household as a boarder: Borodin taught himself to play the cello, Shchiglev the violin.

Science and music

In 1849, Borodin published three salon pieces, and the following year he entered St. Petersburg's prestigious Medical-Surgical Academy to pursue his passion for chemistry. Despite his chemistry professor's disapproval, he continued to compose and perform while working for his PhD, which was awarded in 1858 for a dissertation, entitled "On the Analogy of Arsenic Acid with Phosphoric Acid in Chemical and Toxicological Behavior."

After moving to Heidelberg in 1859 for advanced studies in chemistry, Borodin immersed himself in the city's musical life and met his future wife, Ekaterina Protopopova, a pianist who was in Germany to receive treatment for tuberculosis. She introduced him to music by Chopin, Schumann, and other Romantic composers. Back in St. Petersburg in 1862, Borodin taught at the Medical-Surgical Academy, succeeding his mentor Nikolay Zinin as professor of chemistry. He also joined a group of musicians known as The Five or the Mighty Handful.